

Session 9: What the Prophets Say About the Bible's Origin

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible claims to come from a tradition of prophetic leaders in Israel that stems from Moses.
- The texts reflect a minority report within ancient Israel that comes from those who were faithful to Yahweh and remained true to the covenant.

Joshua as the Guardian of the Covenant Texts

Joshua 1:7-8 NASB*

⁷ Be strong and very courageous; be careful to do according to all **the Torah** which Moses my servant commanded you; do not turn from it to the right or to the left, so that you may have success wherever you go. ⁸ This **scroll of the Torah** shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written in it; for then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have success.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 8:32-35 NASB*

³² [Joshua] wrote there on stones a copy of the **Torah of Moses**, which he had written, in the presence of the sons of Israel. ³³ All Israel with their elders and officers and their judges were standing on both sides of the ark before the Levitical priests who carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh ... ³⁴ Then afterward he read all the **words of the Torah**, the blessing and the curse, according to all that is **written in the book of the Torah**. ³⁵ There was not a word of all that Moses had commanded which Joshua did not read before all the assembly of Israel ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua is presented as a new Moses who guards the covenant Scriptures and who guides Israel in their role as Yahweh's representatives. He is a faithful leader throughout his life.

Notice how Joshua 8 continues the association of the covenant texts with the ark of the covenant. Notice also that the Torah is short enough to be written on memorial stones (like the Mesha Stele here). This likely refers to a "proto-Torah" rather than to the current form of the Torah.



Louvre stèle de Mésha (840) [Wikipedia](#)

National Apostasy and Prophetic Critique

After Joshua dies, Israel abandons its covenant partnership with Yahweh and begins a centuries-long history of apostasy and covenant rebellion.

Judges 2:6-10 NASB*

⁶ When Joshua had dismissed the people, the sons of Israel went each to his inheritance to possess the land. ⁷ **The people served Yahweh all the days of Joshua**, and all the days of the elders who survived Joshua, who had seen all the great work of Yahweh which he had done for Israel. ⁸ Then Joshua the son of Nun, the servant of Yahweh, died at the age of one hundred and ten. ... ¹⁰ All that generation also were gathered to their fathers; **and there arose another generation after them who did not know Yahweh, nor yet the work which he had done for Israel.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

From this point on, Yahweh has to choose from a minority of faithful representatives among the Israelites who are called prophets. They are Yahweh's covenant representatives who provide regular critique and guidance to Israel's kings, priests, and prophets.

The biblical prophets, on the whole, are suspicious of the Israelite institutions of the monarchy, temple priesthood, and the official prophets. Samuel, Nathan, Gad, Elijah, and Elisha all confronted Israel's kings, priests, or prophets.

The prophets spoke in resistance to the Israelite monarchy and its abuses and apostasy, and they critiqued the Israelite priesthood and their sponsored prophets.

1 Samuel 12:13-15, 19-20 NASB*

¹³ "Now therefore, **here is the king whom you have chosen**, whom you have asked for, and behold, the LORD has set a king over you. ¹⁴ If you will fear Yahweh and serve him, and listen to his voice and not rebel against the command of Yahweh, then both you and also the king who reigns over you will follow Yahweh

your God. ¹⁵ **If you will not listen to the voice of Yahweh**, but rebel against the command of Yahweh, **then the hand of Yahweh will be against you**, as it was against your fathers.” ...

¹⁹ Then all the people said to Samuel, “Pray for your servants to Yahweh your God, so that we may not die, for **we have added to all our sins this evil by asking for ourselves a king.**” ²⁰ Samuel said to the people, “Do not fear. **You have committed all this evil**, yet do not turn aside from following the LORD, but serve Yahweh with all your heart.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See also [Amos 7:10-17](#); [Isaiah 39](#); [Jeremiah 36](#)

Jeremiah 5:30-31 NIV*

³⁰ A horrible and shocking thing
has happened in the land:

³¹ The **prophets** prophesy lies,
the **priests** rule by their own authority,
and my people love it this way.
But what will you do in the end?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah 32:32-33 NIV*

³² **The people of Israel and Judah have provoked me** by all the evil they have done—they, **their kings and officials, their priests and prophets**, the people of Judah and those living in Jerusalem. ³³ They turned their backs to me and not their faces ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See also [Hosea 4:4-9](#); [Amos 7:14](#); [Isaiah 28:7](#); [1 Kings 17-19](#)

Late in the Israelite monarchy, the covenant texts of the Scriptures are neglected and forgotten until they are discovered by a Moses-like king (Josiah) and interpreted by a Moses-like prophet (Huldah) in [2 Kings 22:1-20](#).

The Faithful Prophetic Remnant

The biblical scrolls claim to come from a tradition of prophetic leaders in Israel that stems from Moses. These texts reflect a “minority report” within ancient Israel that comes from those who were faithful to Yahweh and remained true to the Sinai covenant.

The story of Judges through 2 Kings depicts the majority of Israelites and their kings as apostate. This portrait could only come from the minority group of Israelites who remained faithful to Yahweh and critical of the majority (think of the “7,000 who haven’t bowed to Baal” in [1 Kgs. 19:14, 18](#)).

For this faithful prophetic remnant within Israel, the Torah remained a source of covenant authority to diagnose Israel’s present failure and a source of future hope for the fulfillment of God’s promises to Abraham.

Hosea uses the Ten Commandments ([Exod. 20](#) and [Deut. 5](#)) and the covenant curses ([Lev. 26](#) and [Deut. 28](#)) to accuse Israel of apostasy in [Hosea 4:1-6](#).

Amos derives much of his language and imagery from the Pentateuch. Covenant curses should generate “repentance” ([Amos 4:6-11](#), derived from [Deut. 28-30](#)).

Pentateuchal narratives are paradigmatic for even the earliest prophets: [Hosea 12:2-4](#) sees Israel’s entire history anticipated in the Jacob narratives of Genesis.

The imagery of future hope is rooted in the storyline and key texts of the Torah: the messianic seed from the line of Judah, the future priest-king who resembles Melchizedek, the need for a new covenant, and the re-creation of the human heart by the power of the Spirit.

The Babylonian Exile and the Making of the Bible

The institutions of the monarchy, priesthood, and court prophets were all eliminated when the nation was scattered from the land and carried off into exile.

Lamentations 2:6-9 NIV*

⁶ He has laid waste **his dwelling** like a garden; he has destroyed **his place of meeting**.

Yahweh has made **Zion** forget her appointed **festivals** and her **Sabbaths**;
in his fierce anger he has spurned both **king and priest**.

⁷ Yahweh has rejected his **altar** and abandoned his **sanctuary**.

He has given the walls of her **palaces** into the hands of the enemy;
they have raised a shout in the **house of Yahweh** as on the day of an appointed festival.

⁸ Yahweh determined to tear down **the wall** around Daughter Zion.

He stretched out a measuring line and did not withhold his hand from destroying.

He made **ramparts** and **walls** lament; together they wasted away.

⁹ Her **gates** have sunk into the ground; their **bars** he has broken and destroyed.

Her **king and her princes** are exiled among the nations,
the **Torah** is no more, and her **prophets** no longer find visions from Yahweh.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

A minority group among the exiles turned to the writings preserved by the true prophets, whose words about Israel’s judgment had come to pass.

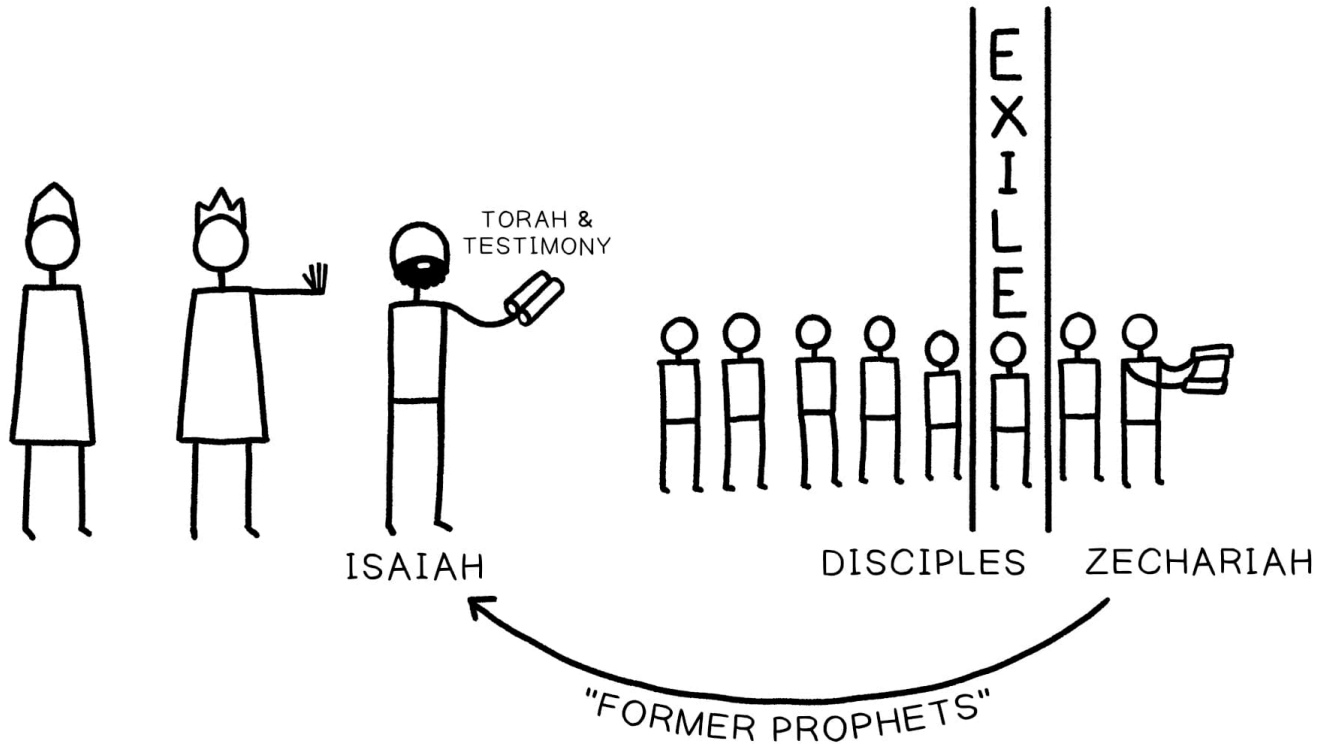
- Isaiah’s *limmudim* (disciples) continued Isaiah’s high view of the prophetic Scriptures ([Isa. 8:11-20](#)).
- Daniel looks to the Mosaic Torah as the product of “Moses and the Prophets” ([Dan. 9:9-10](#)) that points forward to the restoration of the new Jerusalem after a “hyper-Jubilee” period.
- [Malachi 3:16-18](#) reflects the mindset of the community behind the Hebrew Bible. They meditate on the Scriptures, called “the scroll of remembering,” which fosters hope in a future “sorting out” of Israel.

The exiles who return from Babylon have a high view of the Torah and Prophets, and they anticipate the fulfillment of the prophetic promises of restoration.

- Ezra’s main task was to teach the Scriptures ([Ezra 7:6](#), [25-26](#); [Neh. 8](#)).

- The exilic prophets are aware of their dependence on the pre-exilic Scripture (Zech. 1:2-6; 7-8).

The final canonical shape of the TaNaK collection has a post-exilic stamp, and it elevates the importance of immersing oneself in the Scriptures (Josh. 1, Ps. 1) to foster the future hope of restoration (Deut. 34:10-12; Mal. 4:4-5) and countercultural faithfulness in the present.



The Faithful Prophetic Tradition. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

Reflect on the idea that the Hebrew Bible was written over a long period of time by a minority group criticizing the nation's leadership. Does this change or challenge your view of the Hebrew Bible in any way? If so, how? How do you think this idea contributes to what you find in the Hebrew Bible?